

What does it mean for a declarative sentence to have *empirical significance*? To answer this appropriately, we need first to understand what the word *empirical* means. This is no easy task, but perhaps a good way of defining what it means for a sentence to be empirical, is if a real observation can be made to prove the spoken statement correct; and even then it is not that simple. But for a sentence to have empirical significance, it must be *logically equivalent* to a finite set of a certain type of sentences known as *observation sentences*. So then, what does it mean to be ‘logically equivalent’, and what exactly are these ‘observation sentences’? These two terms will first be explained, followed by two objections, both from Lycan, that will be explicated to show that the Verification Theory does not satisfy but only a miniscule portion of how language is used, as well as the strange phenomena of knowing the meaning of a sentence before being able to verify it.

For two sentences to be logically equivalent, they need to both have the same truth values assigned to them. To elaborate, for every pairing of two sentences’ inputs, their output will have the same exact truth value for all of the possible inputs; and if not, then the two sentences lack logical equivalence. Observation sentences are exactly what they sound like: a sentence based on an observation – an experience. Now, the truth value of this type of sentence is subject to change, as everything is subject to change, and this change is what we observe, and then we express what we observe, hence – *observation sentence*. An example would be if someone were to say *It is snowing outside*, but then someone else goes out to verify this statement, yet they see no snow, so they state that *It is not snowing outside*. Does this mean that the first person made a false observation? No, rather the statement was simply expressed after making what was the first observation, in which it was still snowing. Technically, someone on the opposite side of the world could have looked outside to see no snow at the same moment our first person looked

outside and saw snow and they would both be correct in saying that *It is not snowing outside* and *It is snowing outside* with respect to their own observation.

The first objection Lycan posits, states that “the theory applies only to what the positivists called descriptive, fact-stating language”, and that this is “only one type of language” (100). We communicate in a plethora of different ways – ways in which if attempted to all be logically orchestrated, would prove to be quite the challenge. Other examples of how we use language are highlighted by Lycan: we “write poems, tell jokes, perform ceremonies of various kinds, and so on” (101), and when we express ourselves in such ways, it is not always the case that we are using said “descriptive, fact-stating language”. So then, the Verification Theory can only be applied to one of our many uses of language, but since all of the mentioned ways are in-fact meaningful, Lycan believes that “an adequate theory of meaning should apply to all of these uses of language” (101) – a task easier said than done. Therefore, the concept of a declarative sentence only having empirical significance iff it is found to be logically equivalent with a group of observation sentences is faulty because it pertains only to a rather small way in which language is used amongst us.

The second objection of interest rests on the idea of needing to know the meaning of a sentence before being able to verify it. Lycan has us consider the idea of being given a string of words, which we are then to decide whether or not the given string is verifiable. But if it was verifiable, then what was responsible for the verifying? Why is it that we know certain things, yet we don’t seem to know that we know them until attempting to verify them? Do we not obtain knowledge from either being taught, or through some sort of observation within the real world, which in turn supplies us with a majority of the knowledge we need to be able to later verify things? As this may account for most of what we would call *our knowledge* (i.e., memory) which

we in turn use to verify statements, it doesn't account for them all. So strangely, it seems that there are cases in which we can verify a sentence because (whether taught or not) we already know the meaning of the sentence, or in other words, "the question of verifiability and verification conditions is conceptually posterior to knowing what the sentence means" (101). But this is not the aim of the Verification Theory, actually it is "just the opposite" (101). Lycan highlights an important difference between "the sentences that the positivists rule out as meaningless" and those that are held to be "paradigm cases of meaningless strings" (101). This difference being the former strings, "whatever may be wrong with them from an epistemological point of view" (102) (e.g., *None of this is fair.*) should not be considered *meaningless*, especially when compared to strings that we consider to be gibberish (e.g., *wlnvvpqxxi dxq zmq*). This is an important note because we cannot be expected to know the meaning of phrases of gibberish, much less to be able to later verify them, yet we seem to have an understanding regarding the former case of strings.